On September 7, however, the Segals dropped in and Jack asked me what kind of work I was doing. They knew I was doing chemical research at Columbia but knew no details. My mind was full of it at the time so I explained the importance of antimalarials, the nature of quinine, atabrine, and quinacrine, using my hands and fingers to represent chemical formulas. I explained that what we wanted to know was what happened to these substances in the human body to see if these were changed into the real antimalarial and what that might be.

They listened in apparent absorption, and, at the end, Jack said to me, "You're a very good explainer. I wouldn't have thought anyone could have made that clear to me."

I laughed, and was pleased, and we went on to other things, and eventually the Segals went home.

The effect on me, however, was similar to the one that had followed young Emmanuel Bershadsky's praise of The Greenville Chums at College. I had on that earlier occasion begun to think of myself as a

writer; now, as a result of Jack's remark, I began to think of myself as an explainer. I never forgot, and the desire to explain began to grow on me from that day.

What's more, I stopped worrying about Elderfield and his opinion of me. I decided I was good at my work.

Thank you, Jack Segal, wherever you are.

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On September 24, we actually had a phone installed. For the first time since that forty-day period in Dean Street a little over a year before, we could call and receive calls at will.

The very first call we got on our new telephone was a wrong number. We thought that was amusing but it didn't seem so after a while. The French Hospital had a similar number differing only by the inversion of the first two letters. It was a natural error to dial us instead of the hospital.

The hospital received hundreds of calls each day, and of these calls, one out of ten, perhaps (from those with the dimmest minds, of course), would reverse the letters. Up to a dozen times a day, then, the telephone would ring, and